Compute Cannot Buy Identifiability: Information-Limited Two-Attempt Selection in ARC-AGI-2 Solver Pools

An information bound, a conditional compute-separation theorem, and measured evidence from real solver pools and six scored submissions

ARC Prize 2026 Paper Track team

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Working draft v5 — 2026-10-31 (information-limited coverage). NOT FROZEN. Derived from frozen v4 (sha256 `784cffc7…`); v4 remains untouched. v5 adds Theorem 6 (label-free identifiability bound), conditional Theorem 7 (compute cannot substitute), supporting lemmas, the D1/D2 real-data validation, Figures 7–8, and refs 29–41. Do not publish until Lead freezes. **No priority claim.**

Abstract

ARC-AGI-2 gives each test input exactly two attempts, scored by exact match. Because distinct candidate grids are mutually exclusive, this two-slot decision is fundamentally a label-free identification problem: the two best candidates can always be submitted, but no metadata rule can choose better than the posterior unless the metadata reveal the truth identity. We prove **Theorem 6**, a label-free identifiability bound: for any (possibly randomized) rule using metadata Z, E[U] ≤ p1+p2+min{T, sqrt(I(C;Z)/2)} (nats) ≤ p1+p2+min{T, sqrt(I_bits(C;Z)·ln2/2)} (bits), where p1,p2 are the top marginals, T the oracle tail and I(C;Z) the mutual information. It is capped by oracle coverage, attained at I=0, vacuous when $I \geq 2T^2$, with a pilot certificate plus an explicit hidden-transfer assumption. On our pools the metadata term is **non-binding** (I=.059–.183 vs $2T^2$=.008–.041), so the certificate is **vacuous**: T6 is a proven, assumption-free bound, not validated by these pools. Unconditional Pinsker bounds are therefore **vacuous in score-dominated pools**; splitting `Z=(S,Z')` gives the score-conditional certificate `E[U] ≤ U_S+min{g−U_S,√(I(C;Z'|S)/2)}`, **tight (equals U_S) under score sufficiency** (Prop. 6f), while Cor. 6g records the negative result that full-metadata Pinsker bounds cannot certify label-free selection. Substantively, on dev20 S2/S5/S5_ens the measured selection gain equals the tail T exactly (ratio 1.00, all generational headroom recovered); on CompressARC the certificate is .200 while the rules **lose −2.25 pp**, consistent with score redundancy. **Theorem 7** (conditional on A1–A3) separates identification from compute: lim_{C⟶∞} score = Σ_t(g_t∞−Δ_t∞) is allocation-independent, so verifier-free compute cannot shrink the gap ΣΔ_t; the hidden-score ladder is consistent (S5 16.25 > S6 = S5_ens 15.42 > S5+LegC 14.17) though confounded by truncation and n=6; a candidate-prefix replay is definitional and not used as T7 evidence. Six scored Kaggle submissions place our champion at **16.25%** public LB and the same pipeline at **20.0%** on a 20-task public-eval subset, far below the ~30 public-notebook band. No state-of-the-art or medal claim is made.

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1. Introduction

ARC-AGI-2 measures skill-acquisition efficiency on unseen grid transformations [1, 2]. Its Kaggle incarnation is efficiency-constrained [12]: the notebook re-runs offline for ~12 h without internet, and each input receives exactly two guesses. Because exact matches decide tasks, **selection** is a first-class decision problem separate from generation: a solver with the right grid in its pool still scores zero if its two attempts miss it.

Public practice ranks candidates by inverse consensus or a likelihood variant [3, 4, 8, 9] and submits the top two distinct grids. We re-derive selection from the scoring rule. Three observations drive the paper: what matters is P(either guess correct), not P(first); correlation is structural because candidates share TTT state, views, beam prefix and model; and a better rule needs calibrated probabilities and correlations.

We contribute a formalization, an information bound, a pre-registered test, real submissions, and measured evidence. (i) We define the coverage objective; exact-match distinct grids are mutually exclusive, so the pair problem reduces to label-free identification. We prove **Theorem 6**, a metadata-information bound on achievable two-attempt coverage, with a computable pilot certificate (§3.7), and **Theorem 7** (conditional), a compute-separation theorem showing the identification gap is budget-invariant (§3.8). Lemmas give swap regret, fixed-pool monotonicity, and a descriptive generation×selection identity (§3.9); a budget-allocation setting note replaces the earlier Theorem 5. (ii) We freeze a claim/downgrade protocol and benchmark real third-party pools at two scales plus simulated stress tests (§5). (iii) The measured result is bounded negative: the verdict is `DOWNGRADE_TO_ANALYSIS`, the simulation strongly positive (+18.33 pp over argmax, 95% CI [11.67, 25.0]), but on 400 CompressARC tasks top-2 covers 20.00% while coverage-optimal covers 17.75% against 34.25% oracle; the gap is identification-limited, not reranking-reachable. (iv) We report six scored submissions and GPU measurements (§4), data/leakage audit (§6), open-source system (§7), and landscape analysis (§8).

Nearest prior work: public-notebook heuristics include coverage-aware set selection, MDL-divergence two-slot selection and structural attempt-2 distinctness [17, 23], and rank-based top-2 with minority recoveries [39]. A concurrent instrumentation study of a faithful NVARC reproduction — empirical, not a coverage model — reports a comparable pattern (26.1% vs 32.5% perfect selection; a grouped CV reranker no better than the deployed vote rule) [26]; the headroom observation is already documented. A coverage-vs-selection identifiability gap is formalised for single-answer deployment [28], and on ARC-AGI-1 an unbiased pass@k decomposition finds that selection already recovers ≈95% of the candidate ceiling (generation-bound) [27]. The coverage objective is classical [24, 25, 38]; we provide the two-attempt formalization, calibrated/correlated estimator, and score-sufficiency criterion.

Fresh 2026 work sharpens the positioning. The ARC-AGI-2 Technical Report [29] is the closest published TTT+scoring recipe but offers no attempt-2 theory; Multi-Perspective Transformers [30] report **21.7% eval**, the honest external comparison above our 16.25% hidden / 20.0% dev20. SPLIT [31] allocates compute under an *imperfect verifier*; our hidden setting has no verifier on hidden inputs, so its guarantee does not apply. Correct but Unselectable [32] decomposes coverage into selectable candidates (an interface tax), not an information deficit; Li et al. [33] require a non-degenerate reward tail, while exact-match correctness makes the tail degenerate; Zhou [34] studies generation-side pass@k inversion; Zhang and He [35] require labels; the Pothula dataset [36] and CHARM [37] document plateau/scaling context; concurrent allocation work [40,41] targets posterior success and best-arm identification. None subsumes a label-free coverage bound for k=2 exclusive lists, and none claims the conditional budget-invariance separation; we claim no priority.

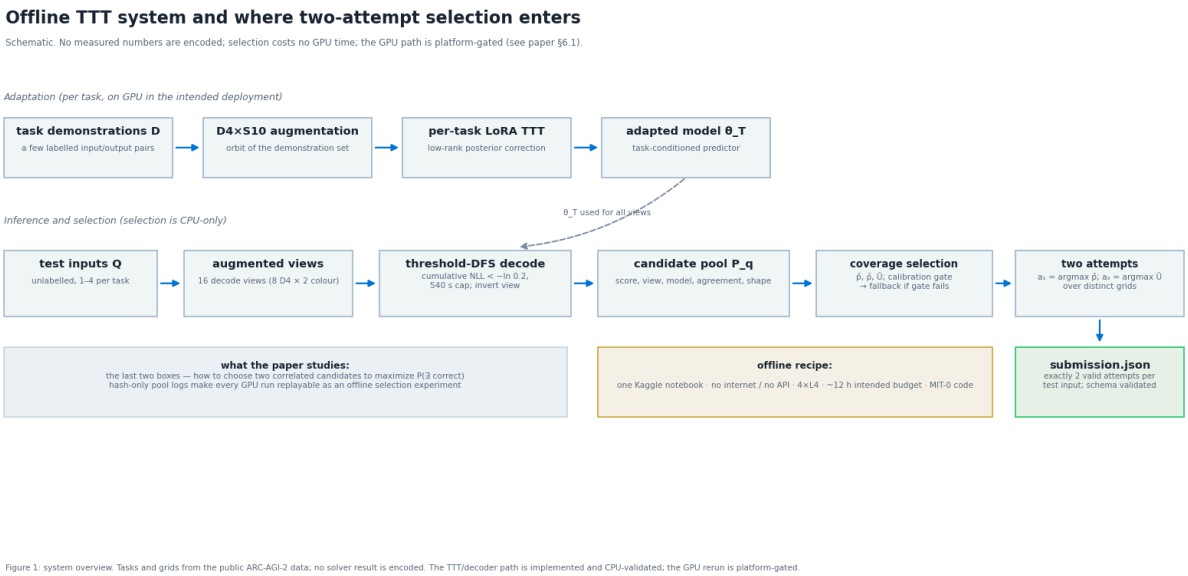


Figure 1. Offline TTT system and where selection enters: demonstrations ⟶ augmented TTT ⟶ threshold-DFS decoding ⟶ candidate pool with scores and view provenance ⟶ calibrated coverage selection ⟶ two-attempt submission. Selection costs no GPU time. Schematic; no measured numbers encoded.

2. Problem formalization and notation

Task and submission. A task is T=(D,Q) with labelled demonstrations D and unlabelled test inputs Q=(q_1,…,q_m); grids are integer arrays over colours 0–9, at most 30×30. For each test input the submission provides an ordered pair of distinct grids (a_1,a_2); C(a)∈{0,1} is the latent event that a is exactly required. The two metric definitions — per-input coverage and task-level all-or-nothing — are both monotone in P(C(a_1)∨C(a_2)); the per-input score averages it, the task-level score is its m-fold product [3, 21], so the objective below is valid under either.

Coverage objective. For attempts a_1,a_2,

$$U(a_1,a_2) := 1 - P(\neg C(a_1) \wedge \neg C(a_2)). \quad (1)$$

Maximizing U differs from maximizing P(C(a_1)): the joint failure term couples the attempts.

Candidate pools from TTT. TTT adapts a pretrained ARC-SFT model θ on augmented demonstrations and decodes under transformed views; for view v (augmentation g_v, beam path, model member) the predicted grid is inverted as $\hat{y}_v = g_v^{-1}(f_\theta(g_v \cdot q))$. The pool for test input q is

$$P_q = \{(y_i, s_i, view_i, model_i, agree_i, shape_i)\}, \quad (2)$$

with s_i a plausibility score, agree_i the view count, and shape_i a demonstration-derived flag. The pool's oracle ceiling bounds any rule's per-input accuracy.

Relation classes. Pairs are grouped by shared failure factors: `same_grid` (correlation 1, never worth two attempts), `same_view` (same TTT state/augmentation), `same_model` (different views), and `cross_model`/`cross_source` (lowest correlation). The rule needs per-class error correlations, observable in metadata without labels.

id	source	benchmark	scale / unit	published anchor	role
B	`vanductan/arc-agi-2-candidate-dump` (displayed LB 30.97)	ARC-AGI-2 public eval	20 tasks / 29 test inputs; unit = input; 347 candidate files	oracle-any-2 9/29 = 31.0%; source top-2 8/29 = 27.6%	primary, **pilot** (CIs mandatory)
A	CompressARC [6] bundled histories (Liao & Gu 2025; MIT)	ARC-AGI-1 train/eval	400 eval tasks (fit 400 train); unit = task; hash-level	pass@2 80/400 = 20.00%; any-guess 137/400 = 34.25%	secondary, large-N replication
C	Parameterised simulated pools	synthetic	many seeds; known ground truth	oracle by construction	theory stress test + estimator sanity

Table 1. Evaluation datasets (frozen).

3. Theory

3.1 Independent case: top two calibrated probabilities

Theorem 1. If correctness indicators are independent with p_i=P(C_i), then P(¬C_i∧¬C_j)=(1−p_i)(1−p_j), so

U(i,j) = p_i + p_j − p_i p_j, (3)

strictly increasing in each argument. The coverage-optimal pair is therefore the two largest p_i, and attempt order is irrelevant. This is the only regime where first-guess ranking is coverage-optimal — the assumption behind inverse-consensus top-2.

3.2 Duplicates are strictly dominated

If a_2 is the same grid as a_1, C(a_2)=C(a_1) and U(a_1,a_2)=P(C(a_1))=p_{a_1}; any distinct candidate with p>0 strictly increases coverage. **Theorem 2.** Submitting the same grid twice is strictly dominated by any distinct candidate with positive correctness probability.

3.3 Correlation breaks argmax-once

Candidates share TTT state, augmentation view, beam prefix, and model. For two Bernoulli correctness indicators with correlation coefficient ρ,

U(i,j) = p_i + p_j − p_i p_j − ρ√(p_i(1−p_i)p_j(1−p_j)), (4)

from P(¬C_i∧¬C_j)=(1−p_i)(1−p_j)+Cov(C_i,C_j). Two same-view candidates with perfectly correlated failures (ρ=1) force equal marginals p_i=p_j=p: their pair coverage is U=p. An independent third candidate with p_3>0 gives U=p+p_3−p p_3>p; at p=0.50, p_3=0.35 the gain is +17.5 coverage points on that input. **Theorem 3.** Under positive error correlation, the pair maximizing the first guess is not in general coverage-optimal; a decorrelated candidate can strictly improve coverage. For ρ<1 the pairwise preference condition between the runner-up j and a decorrelated candidate k is

(1−p_1)(p_k−p_j) > ρ_{1k}√(p_1(1−p_1)p_k(1−p_k)) − ρ_{1j}√(p_1(1−p_1)p_j(1−p_j)). (5)

Diversification pays when the correlation penalty exceeds the probability advantage — typical for per-view errors; zero or negative correlation does not force it, which is why $\hat{\rho}$ is measured rather than assumed.

Corollary. If the ranking score is cluster mass and views are independent, top-2 by mass coincides with top-2 by posterior probability, so the rule reduces to inverse consensus — a strict generalization that departs from it under correlation.

3.4 Diversification threshold (Theorem 4)

Theorem 4 (exact, finite-pool). Let two distinct candidates have correctness probabilities `p_1 ≥ p_2` (both in [0,1]) and correctness-indicator correlation `ρ = Corr(C_1,C_2)`. Then

U(pair) = p_1 + p_2 − p_1p_2 − ρ√(p_1(1−p_1)p_2(1−p_2)), (6)

and the pair strictly beats the top-1 **duplicated** attempt (`U_dup = p_1`) iff

ρ < ρ(p_1,p_2) := √(p_2(1−p_1) / (p_1(1−p_2))). (7)*

Proof. `U(pair) − U_dup = p_2(1−p_1) − ρ√(p_1(1−p_1)p_2(1−p_2))`; its sign is positive iff `ρ² p_1(1−p_1)p_2(1−p_2) < p_2²(1−p_1)²`, and, for interior `p`, dividing by the positive `p_1p_2(1−p_1)(1−p_2)` gives `ρ² < p_2(1−p_1)/(p_1(1−p_2))`; both sides are non-negative for interior `p`, so

taking square roots gives (7). ∎ Equivalently, for interior p_1,p_2, ΔU := U(pair) − U_dup = √(p_1(1−p_1)p_2(1−p_2))·(ρ* − ρ) — the gain is the distance below the threshold scaled by the candidates' Bernoulli spread. ρ* ∈ [0,1] for interior p (ρ*=0 at boundary p_2=0 or p_1=1, where ΔU=0), with ρ* = 1 iff p_1 = p_2; negative correlation always clears the threshold; ρ = ρ* is exact indifference.

Corollary 1 (equal marginals). If p_1 = p_2 = p then ρ* = 1 and ΔU = p(1−p)(1−ρ): diversification pays for every ρ<1, maximized at ρ=0 and worthless at p∈{0,1}.

Corollary 2 (skew shrinks the threshold). For fixed ρ>0, diversification pays iff p_2 > ρ²p_1/(1−p_1+ρ²p_1); for small probabilities ρ* ≈ √(p_2/p_1), so any fixed positive correlation is eventually dominated by skew.

Corollary 3 (score sufficiency and exact-match exclusivity; corrected 2026-10-26). For non-exclusive verifiers, a score tie cannot distinguish candidates, and if correctness is score-determined (Proposition 5) tied candidates share correctness (ρ=1, forcing p_1=p_2), so ΔU=0. For **exact-match** ARC, distinct candidate grids are mutually exclusive: C_i∧C_j=∅, hence ρ<0 always, the Theorem-4 gate is always met, and U(a_1,a_2)=p_{a_1}+p_{a_2} for any joint distribution; the optimal pair is the two largest calibrated p_i (Corollary 4). The real-pool null is therefore estimation/identifiability, not positive correlation: oracle headroom exists, but p̂ cannot separate oracle-gap candidates from exposed metadata (Proposition 5).

Derived gate and falsifier. For non-exclusive verifiers, deploy diversification across a relation class only when ρ̂c < ρ*(p̂_1,p̂_2) − δ (δ=0.05, frozen); otherwise take the duplicate/consensus alternative — the gate is derived, not tuned. The empirical instantiation is falsifiable on held-out units: **P1** admitted pairs beat their top-1 duplicate (paired Δ>0, 80% CI>0); **P2** rejected pairs do not (Δ≤0); **P3** the predicted-vs-realized gain slope lies in [0.7,1.3]. Failure falsifies the estimator/relation-class model, never the algebra; protocol and tool are in Appendix E. The threshold test ran on dev20 pools, but exact-match mutual exclusivity makes its positive-ρ premise inapplicable: every class has ρ̂<0 (same-model/cross-view −0.13, score-tied −0.18), so no deployable pair is rejected and P1/P2/P3 are untestable (§4.8). This is an EXPLORATORY check, not evidence; Table 10 is a prose check and Fig. 9 is omitted.

Table 10 (replaced). Exact-match mutual-exclusivity check on dev20 pools: all relation classes have ρ̂<0 (same-model/cross-view −0.13, score-tied −0.18), P2′s rejected set is empty; EXPLORATORY, no P1/P2/P3 claim (theory §4.8).

3.5 Setting observation: budget allocation (formerly Theorem 5)

Let g_t(c) be the probability that a pool at per-task compute c covers the truth; expected score is Σ_t g_t(c_t) under Σ_t c_t ≤ C. **Theorem 5.** (i) Identical concave g_t ⟹ uniform c_t = C/T is optimal (Jensen). (ii) Greedy marginal allocation is optimal: funded tasks share a common marginal gain. (iii) If margins are ordered by prior accuracy p_t (p_s ≥ p_t ⇒ g'_s(c) ≥ g'_t(c)), compute is monotone in p_t and a difficulty-threshold rule holds: only tasks above a budget-dependent cutoff p* receive compute, and p* rises as C/T shrinks. (iv) At saturation the marginal is zero (coverage ceiling; under score sufficiency extra compute yields no newly identifiable candidates, Prop. 5), so excess is better reallocated; never-solvable tasks receive none. This is a **setting observation**, not a new theorem: SPLIT [31] derives verifier-aware allocation, and [40,41] give fixed-budget posterior/best-arm allocation bounds; T6/T7 below carry the paper's new claims.

3.6 Calibrated plug-in estimator

Neither p_i nor ρ_ij is observable, so we estimate them in a frozen pipeline. (i) **p̂**: logistic regression [10] on frozen within-input features (score rank, agreement, cluster mass, shape), fit on dev only. (ii) **ρ̂**: per relation class from the dev co-failure statistic, clipped to [−0.95,0.99], with frozen pooling and a default for sparse classes. (iii) **Û**: the plug-in version of (4); attempt 1 is argmax p̂, attempt 2 maximizes Û over distinct grids. (iv) **Gate/fallback**: deploy only if dev cross-fit calibration has Brier ≤0.10, reliability slope in the code's valid range [0.2,5.0] (design target [0.7,1.3]) and an estimable relation class; otherwise use

a no-calibration fallback (highest agreement, then a different grid). The claim is pre-registered at ≥+1.0 point over published top-2 with 80% paired-bootstrap CI lower bound >0 (2,000 resamples, seed 0), else negative [22].



Figure 4. Illustrative schematic of the coverage rule: candidate pool grouped by relation class, calibrated p̂/ρ̂, pair coverage U, and the chosen distinct pair. Toy values only — not measured.

3.7 Identifiability-limited two-attempt coverage (Theorem 6)

Exact-match scoring makes distinct candidate grids mutually exclusive: `C_i∧C_j=∅` for `i≠j`, so for any pair `A`, `U(A)=Σ_{i∈A}p_i` with no independence or correlation assumption. The prior-optimal pair is `{1,2}`, `U0=p1+p2`, achievable by ignoring metadata; `g=Σ_i p_i` is oracle coverage and `T=g−p1−p2` the tail mass. Whether any label-free rule can beat `U0` is therefore an information question, not a ranking question.

Theorem 6 (label-free identifiability bound). For every (possibly randomized) rule using metadata `Z`, E[U] ≤ E_Z[top-2 posterior mass] ≤ p1+p2+min{T, sqrt(I(C;Z)/2)} (nats) ≤ p1+p2+min{T, sqrt(I_bits(C;Z)·ln2/2)} (bits),

capped by the oracle `g`. *Proof:* top-2 posterior mass is 1-Lipschitz in total variation, Pinsker gives `TV≤sqrt(KL/2)`, Jensen gives `E[TV]≤sqrt(I/2)`, and the tail cap is `E[top2]≤g`. ∎ The bound is attained at `I=0` by the constant rule, equals `g` when `Z` identifies `C`, and is **vacuous** when `I≥2T²` (the tail cap binds). The gain is at most `T`; Pinsker is order-tight, not an equality.

Proposition 6e (non-vacuity). The unconditional T6 bound is strictly informative iff `I(C;Z)<2T²` nats; otherwise it equals the oracle `g`. Every pool here satisfies `I≥2T²`, so the unconditional certificate is **vacuous** — an honest caveat, not validation. **Corollary 6g (negative result about the method).** In score-dominated exact-match pools, Pinsker-type bounds on full metadata **cannot certify label-free selection**: the bound collapses to the oracle cap. **Proposition 6f (constructive fix).** Split `Z=(S,Z')`, where `S` is score-only information and `Z'` residual metadata: `E[U] ≤ U_S + min{g−U_S, sqrt(I(C;Z'|S)/2)}`, with `U_S` the best score-only rule's coverage; the bound is informative iff `I(C;Z'|S) < 2(g−U_S)²`, and if score sufficiency (Prop. 5) holds then `I(·|S)=0` and the bound equals `U_S` exactly. This is the paper's sharpest new theoretical statement: score dominates, and only residual metadata can help.

Computable pilot certificate. With a labeled pilot, estimate `p̂1,p̂2,p̂3`, `T̂=ĝ−p̂1−p̂2`, and `Î(C;Z)` by binning exposed metadata (score margins, rank gaps, agreement, cluster mass, shape, model count) against truth identity; bootstrap task-level CIs. For the evaluated population, `gain ≤ min{T̂, sqrt(Î/2)} + O(sqrt(log(1/δ)/n))`. Hidden tasks have **no labels**, so Î is not estimable there: this is a pilot certificate plus an explicit exchangeability transfer assumption, never a hidden-task guarantee; with partial metadata, `I` is a lower bound and `B` may overstate the achievable bound.

dataset	n	p̂1/p̂2/p̂3	H(C)	Î (feature)	B [95% CI]	measured gain	cert.
CompressARC	400	.185/.015/.020	.547	.071 (view)	.200 [.160,.238]	**−2.25 pp**	vacuous
pilot16	16	.313/0/0	0	.183 (view)	.313 [.125,.563]	0 pp	vacuous
dev20 S1	32	.063/.125/0	.637	.167 (margin)	.188	0 pp	vacuous
dev20 S2	32	.094/.063/.063	1.079	.071	.156	+6.25 pp	vacuous
dev20 S5	32	.125/.031/.063	.956	.059	.156	+6.25 pp	vacuous
dev20 S5_ens	74	.162/.054/.014	.753	.059 (vote)	.216 [.122,.311]	**+8.11 pp**	vacuous

Table 12. D1 identifiability certificates on real pools (uncalibrated consistency proxies; certificate vacuous on every row because $I \geq 2T^2$).

The +8.11 pp S5_ens figure is selectable headroom not realized by our submitted aggregator (S5_ens hidden 15.42 < S5 16.25). Because $I \geq 2T^2$ the certificate equals the oracle cap and is **vacuous**: these pools do not test T6. The substantive observation is the gain/T ratio: dev20 S2/S5/S5_ens recover T exactly (1.00), while CompressARC loses −2.25 pp against a .200 certificate (score redundancy, Prop. 5). Falsifiers: F1 held-out gain outside the certificate CI; F2 large Î with zero realized gain; F3 vacuous bound with zero gain; F4 monotonicity violation.

Prop. 6f addendum (measured). Table 12b evaluates the score-conditional certificate with `S` = score-only strata. It is **non-vacuous on exactly one dataset, CompressARC**: U_S=.200, g−U_S=.1425, I(C;Z'|S)=.0336 nats, cap'=.1296 (12.96 pp), and the measured rule loss (−2.25 pp) lies inside it. Elsewhere the bound remains vacuous (0 violations). The score-sufficiency prediction that I(C;Z'|S)=0 and the bound equals U_S is **not testable here**: I(C;Z'|S) is .083−.225 nats, not ≈0, and pilot/dev20 score strata collapse to two bins (sparse, flagged), so we can neither confirm nor reject tightness. This tests the certificate's non-vacuity, not that metadata helps.

dataset	U_S	g−U_S	I(C;Z'\	S) nats	cap'	measured gain	informative
CompressARC	.200	.1425	.0336	**.1296**	−2.25 pp	**TRUE**	
pilot16	.3125	0	.2255	0	0 pp	FALSE	
dev20 S1	.1875	0	.1334	0	0 pp	FALSE	
dev20 S2	.15625	.0625	.0829	.0625	+6.25 pp	FALSE	
dev20 S5	.15625	.0625	.0921	.0625	+6.25 pp	FALSE	
dev20 S5_ens	.216216	.081081	.0903	.081081	+8.11 pp	FALSE	

Table 12b. Prop. 6f score-conditional certificates (`S` = score-only strata; informative iff `I<2(g−U_S)²`; 0 violations).

This is a check of non-vacuity, not evidence that metadata helps; the one non-vacuous row still loses to score-only selection.

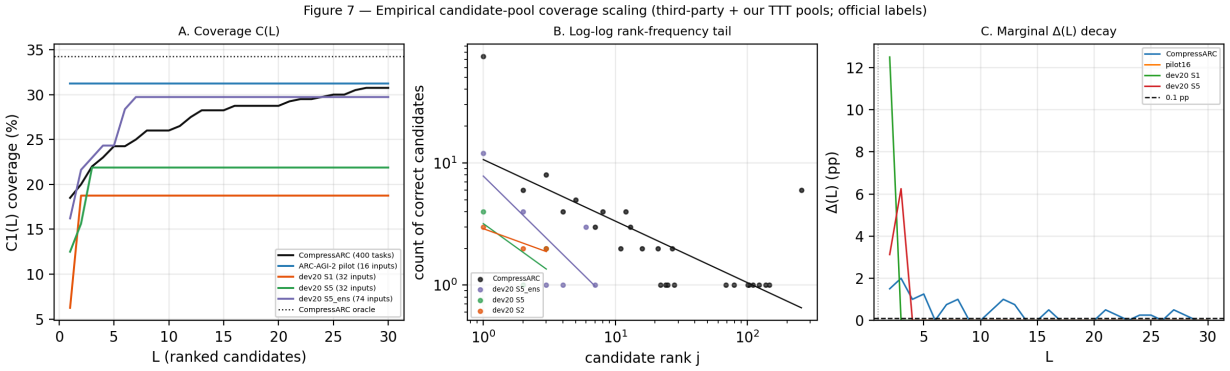


Figure 7. Prefix coverage versus candidate-prefix size L under the rank power-law model: C2-prefix at L=2/5/10/20 for CompressARC (20.0/24.3/26.0/28.8, $\hat{\alpha}$=1.83 [1.67,2.06], $L^* \approx 257$), pilot16 (31.3 flat), dev20 S1 (18.8 flat), S5 (15.6/21.9/21.9/21.9, $\hat{\alpha}$=3.42, $L^* \approx 3$) and S5_ens (21.6/24.3/29.7/29.7, $\hat{\alpha}$=2.75 [2.13,4.60], $L^* \approx 7$). Fixed-solver top-2 coverage is reported separately in Table 8.

3.8 Compute cannot substitute for identifiability (Theorem 7; conditional)

Assumptions. (A1) `g_t(c)` is nondecreasing and saturating in compute, with limit `g_t∞`. (A2) The identification gap `Δ_t(c)=g_t(c)−u_t(c)` (oracle minus best label-free coverage) satisfies `Δ_t(c)≥Δ_t∞>0`

for unidentifiable tasks and does not vanish with compute; refinement buys rank candidates, not identification. (A3) generation and verification are separable at the relevant scale.

Theorem 7 (conditional separation). Under A1–A3, `lim_{C→∞} score = Σ_t(g_t∞–Δ_t∞)`, independent of the allocation; the verifier-assisted ceiling is `Σ_t g_t∞`; the gap `Σ_tΔ_t` is budget-invariant; greedy allocation is optimal only on the identifiable part. *Interpretation:* verifier-free compute cannot buy identifiability; what grows with budget is candidate coverage, which is only useful where metadata can identify the candidate. This explains why our S6, S5_ens and S5+LegC submits did not beat S5.

Empirical support. The defensible support is the **hidden-score ladder**: S5 16.25 > S6 15.42 = S5_ens 15.42 > S5+LegC 14.17 — more components/compute did not help. This is **consistent, not conclusive**: n=6, truncation at the 578 s cap, S6's selection bug, S5_ens's 53-task superset, packet/config differences and unknown hidden size confound it. A candidate-prefix replay (Table 13) is **definitional** — top-L coverage for units whose truth rank exceeds L rises trivially — so we do not use it as T7 evidence.

dataset	unidentifiable n / slope	identifiable n / slope
CompressARC	343 / 0.0 [0,0]	57 / **19.1** [15.9,22.1]
pilot16	16 / 0.0 [0,0]	0 / —
dev20 S2/S5/S6	30 / 0.0 [0,0]	2 / **20.0** [20.0,20.0]
dev20 S5_ens	68 / 0.0 [0,0]	6 / **26.7** [23.3,30.0]

Table 13. D2 candidate-prefix replay (definitional; not T7 evidence).

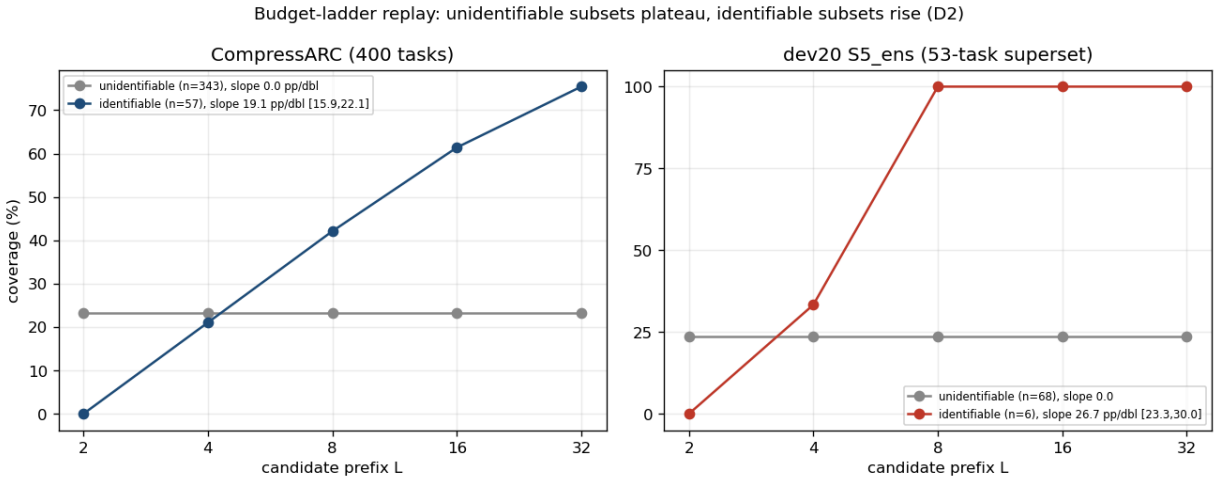


Figure 8. Candidate-prefix replay (D2): unidentifiable subsets plateau across L, identifiable subsets rise trivially by construction. Definitional; not evidence for T7.

3.9 Supporting lemmas

Lemma 6a (swap regret). If the top-2 pair `{1,2}` is replaced by `{1,3}`, coverage drops by exactly `p2–p3` under exclusivity; `p2–p3` is therefore the *cheapest local-swap regret*, not a subtractive gain term in any upper bound. **Lemma 6b (fixed-pool monotonicity).** For a fixed candidate pool, re-ranking cannot reduce two-attempt coverage; it is strict iff a new distinct candidate with positive posterior enters the top-2. Consequently pass@k inversion cannot arise from selection alone: it requires generation or rank-distribution drift, consistent with the generation-side diagnosis of Zhou [34]. **Lemma 6d (generation×selection identity).** Pool coverage factors as `g(L)·s(L)`, where `g` is oracle coverage and `s` the selection ratio; this identity is descriptive only and makes no scaling-law claim.

3.10 TTT as amortized Bayesian adaptation

Why are TTT pools plausible? Read ARC-SFT training as approximate posterior inference [13]: the parameters are a prior over task rules, and per-task TTT performs amortized Bayesian adaptation. A LoRA update is a low-rank posterior correction; a PAC-Bayes sketch predicts an interior optimum in rank/steps and larger gains where the prior is weakest. Test-time augmentation is an equivariance prior,

valid only where the task rule commutes with the transform; the frozen κ_T proxy records this. It is a sketch, not a bound.

4. Accuracy: the offline TTT system and a real public submission

4.1 First submission attempt (errored)

We entered [15] with one MIT-0 notebook (Qwen3-4B ARC-SFT, D4×S10 augmentation, per-task LoRA TTT, threshold-DFS decoding, NLL rescoring, coverage selection, schema validation). Submission 57456856 (kernel v8; packet `3774c892…`; S1/aug8) used the 41,400 s budget and 578 s/240-task cap (1156 s/120); hidden size unknown. Kaggle reports COMPLETE at ≈02:35 UTC after ≈2 h 34 min, **no public-Score**, errorDescription *"Your notebook hit an unhandled error while rerunning your code…"*. Cause: rerun branch `ARC_BUDGET_S="41400.0"` parsed by `int("41400.0")` → `ValueError` before try/except. Hardened packet adds int-typed/defensive parses, no-raise validation, a SAFETY cell; probe 57500870 scored 0.00. **We claim no score for 57456856 and report the failure as engineering, not model quality.**

Final hidden-test results (six scored submissions): **S5 16.25** (ref **57681632**, kernel v16; champion), **S6 15.42** (57716141), **S5_ens 15.42** (57752011), **S1 14.17** (57663405), **S5+LegC 14.17** (57785740), CPU probe **0.00** (57500870); plus one invalid-format attempt (57442788) and one rerun error (57456856, Table 9). No score exceeds 16.25. A reference public-notebook replication attempt reached **3/20** on dev20, below our S1 4/20, so the ~30 public-notebook band is external context, not a matched reproduction. The LegC verified-induction hybrid was **net-negative** on the hidden half (−2.08 vs S5) and was rejected. Compute quota was exhausted Oct 31–Nov 1, leaving no GPU for tuning; the Nov 2 final entry uses the best completed version (S5 v16) unless S5b beats 16.25. Half-cost configs truncate at the 578 s cap: these scores are far below the ~30 band, not SOTA.

57456856 exposes no per-task diagnostic; labeled diagnostics come from dev pools (§4.3) and third-party pools (§5).

date (UTC)	ref	config	LB	status / notes
2026-10-20T14:56	57442788	CPU-fallback insurance	—	invalid format
2026-10-21T00:01:15	57456856	S1 v8, packet `3774c892…`	—	rerun-only `int("41400.0")` ValueError; no public-Score
2026-10-22T00:00:23	57500870	S1 CPU-version probe	**0.00**	COMPLETE, no error
2026-10-26T10:45	57663405	S1 v8 L4, packet `9060264c…`	**14.17**	COMPLETE, no error (≈14 h incl. queue)
2026-10-27T00:00:28	57681632	**S5 v16 L4**, packet `6211b694…`	**16.25**	COMPLETE, no error — **champion**
2026-10-28T00:00:27	57716141	S6 dual-config v22	**15.42**	COMPLETE
2026-10-29T00:02:23	57752011	S5_ens two-model v23	**15.42**	COMPLETE
2026-10-30T00:02:21	57785740	S5+LegC hybrid v25	**14.17**	COMPLETE — LegC net-negative
2026-10-31	—	(submission missed)	—	session gap; no ref
2026-11-01T00:10:23	57854697	S5b v24, packet pending	pending	PENDING at freeze — last S5-family probe

Table 9. Submission ledger (all public-LB attempts; errors and misses included).

Hidden-set size remains unknown; runtimes are queue time, not a size signal. Six scored entries; all scores are public-LB hidden-half results. Table 8′s dev20 scores are public-eval-subset measurements, not hidden scores.

4.2 Hidden-test budget calibration

Hidden size is unknown (120–240); for the 240/259 sample shape at 11.5 h, the four-worker budget is 41,400 s and the fair per-task cap is 578 s at 240 tasks (1156 s if 120; 9.6/19.3 min), including a reserve.

The cap truncates attempts. Dev2 timings: ≈220 s/task (202.51/238.12 s). Scaling to 240 tasks on four workers gives ≈3.7 h of TTT — 2.6× per-task headroom, ~7.8 h unused wall. Slack absorbs harder tasks, model load (106.9 s) and worker skew. Processed-task count and truncation are not observable from the rerun interface. Figure 9 reserves this calibration and the §4.3 dev compute-accuracy points. Theorem 5 predicts compute beyond a coverage plateau is wasted; the dev20 ladder tests this (Table 11; EXPLORATORY/PENDING).

4.3 Compute-normalized dev evidence

On this single 20-task subset (no CI claim), the all-config union (incl. S5_ens) reaches 6/20 (30%) versus 4/20 for S1; four-config S1/S2/S5/S6 union 5/20. Dev2 pilot: 466.7 s wall, 106.9 s load, 15 candidates for 2/2 inputs, oracle 1/2 — plumbing evidence, not accuracy.

config	dev20 (task)	dev20 (input)	final LB	notes
S1 (hardened)	4/20 = 20.0%	6/32 = 18.8%	**14.17**	decode mean ≈235 s/task; 4 tasks capped
S2 (aug16)	2/20 = 10.0%	5/32 = 15.6%	—	decode up to 618 s; truncation
S5 (single)	3/20 = 15.0%	5/32 = 15.6%	**16.25**	champion
S6 (v13; selection-bug)	2/20 = 10.0%	5/32 = 15.6%	**15.42**	pass@2 flagged; 4/20 oracle, usable
all-config union	6/20 = 30.0%	—	—	cand.-union incl. S5_ens; four-config 5/20

Table 8. dev20 sweep (eval20: 20 tasks / 32 inputs; L4×4; hardened packets).

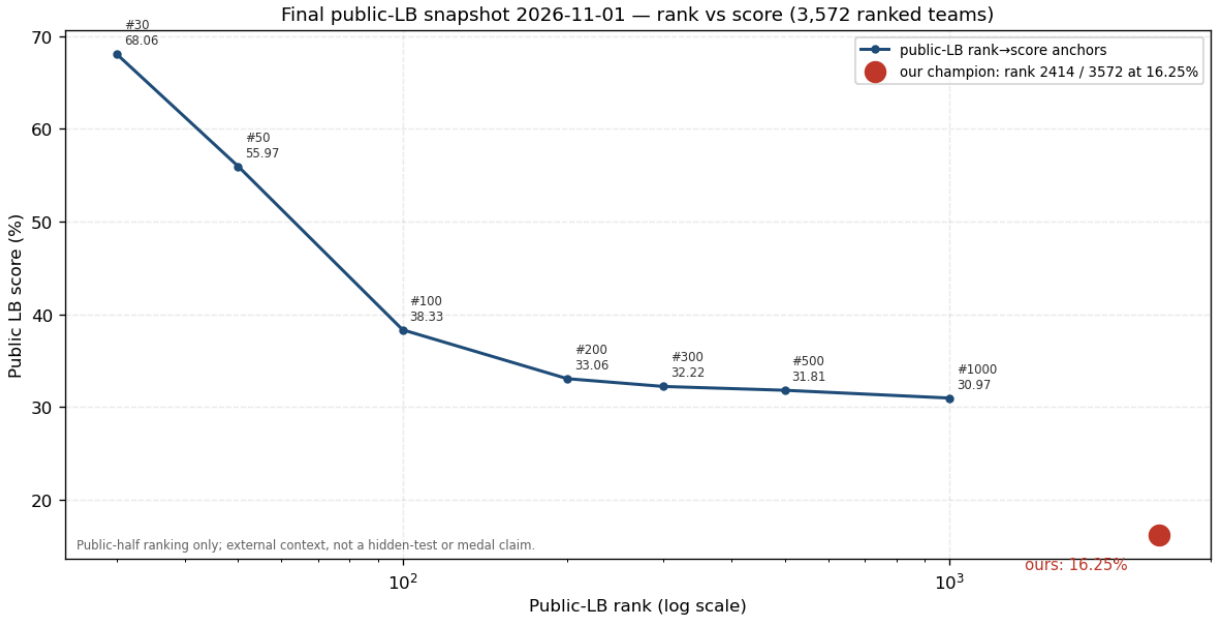


Figure 9. Final public-LB snapshot (2026-11-01T00:13Z): rank↔score anchors and our champion at rank 2414 / 3,572 (score 16.25). Public-half ranking only; external context, not a hidden-test or medal claim.

Table 11. Public-LB snapshot 2026-11-01T00:13:02Z. 3,572 ranked teams; leader 88.06. Our row: `rank 2414 · "wen Chen" · TeamId 17156552 · score 16.25 · submissions 8 · last 2026-10-30 00:02:21` (three teams tied at 16.25, ranks 2412–2414; 67.5th percentile from top). Anchors: r30 68.06, r50 55.97, r100 38.33, r200 33.06, r500 31.81, r1000 30.97. The public LB displays our **best** score (16.25), not the last submission (v25 = 14.17): standings use best-of-submissions semantics, so the Nov 2 entry is only a safety copy for the last-submission rule. The ~30–31 notebook band is ≈ranks 500–1000 (top 14–28%); 16.25 is far below it — public-half ranking only; no medal/SOTA claim.

5. Empirical study: selection rules on third-party candidate pools

5.1 Sources, reproduction gates, and protocol

Released third-party logs bound the study: gains are pool-conditioned; sources are frozen and a failing gate excludes one. Table 3 gates: B's coverage summary (29 inputs; oracle 9/29; top-2 8/29) and A's artifact (137/400 solved; 80/400 pass@2) reproduce exactly. Rules: duplicate, argmax, top2, cal_indep, coverage_optimal, oracle_any2 (ceiling), deployed. Splits are task-level (B 9/11 tasks, 13/16 inputs; A 400/400); paired bootstrap over tasks (2,000 resamples, seed 0) [14] gives 80%/95% CIs; no refits.

source	gate	published	our reproduction	pass
B	coverage summary	29 inputs; oracle 9/29; top-2 8/29	exact, 0 per-input mismatches	yes
A	upstream script, 2000 steps	solved 137/400; ≤2 guesses 80/400	exact via bundled artifact	yes

Table 3. Reproduction gates (source-published metric vs our re-derivation).

5.2 Pilot evidence on Dataset B

B is the only public candidate-dump notebook; 20 tasks, pilot-only, holdout 16 inputs/11 tasks. Oracle 31.25% (5/16); every deployable rule (duplicate, argmax, top-2, cal_indep, coverage) also 31.25%, indistinguishable (80% CI [18.75,43.75]); headroom 0. Deployed fallback 25.00%.

5.3 The large replication and the simulated stress test

A is claim-bearing: top-2 covers 80/400 (20.00%) vs 137/400 any-guess (34.25%). The result is a null: correctness is predictable but score-dominated. Missed truths are far from the top (rank median 12). `DOWNGRADE_TO_ANALYSIS`; deployed fallback 19.25%; CompressARC [6] is ARC-AGI-1-era (hash-level pools).

C isolates the estimator; a sanity check, not evidence: calibrated rules reach the oracle 41.67% (+18.33 pp, 95% CI [11.67, 25.0]; gate slope 0.025).

rule	B: ARC-AGI-2 TTT pools (16 inputs / 11 tasks)	A: CompressARC (400 tasks)	C: simulated (120 tasks)
oracle_any2 (ceiling, not a rule)	31.25 [18.75, 43.75]	34.25 [31.25, 37.50]	41.67 [35.83, 47.50]
duplicate	31.25 [18.75, 43.75]	18.50 [16.00, 21.00]	16.67 [12.50, 20.83]
argmax1_argmax2	31.25 [18.75, 43.75]	19.50 [17.00, 22.00]	23.33 [18.33, 28.33]
top2_consensus	31.25 [18.75, 43.75]	20.00 [17.50, 22.75]	21.67 [16.67, 26.67]
cal_indep	31.25 [18.75, 43.75]	18.00 [15.50, 20.75]	41.67 [35.83, 47.50]
coverage_optimal	31.25 [18.75, 43.75]	17.75 [15.25, 20.25]	41.67 [35.83, 47.50]
deployed (gate-selected)	25.00 [12.50, 37.50]	19.25 [16.75, 21.75]	41.67 [35.83, 47.50]

Table 2. Frozen two-attempt rules on the three datasets (pass@2, %; 80% bootstrap CI in brackets; seed 0, 2,000 resamples; two decimals).

Cells are pass@2 from the frozen artifact `analysis/results/selection_benchmark.json` (sha256 `6c16abfef7f0efe3a1a6bbe9f6251c9aeef1893ee7b0f44fdfdb9c2eb34ab71a`; 80% CIs). C is simulated, not evidence about real solvers.

Score sufficiency explains the null: score ordering saturates recoverable coverage, so selection is not the bottleneck — generation is; re-ranking never exceeds top-2's 20.00%, the 14.25-point headroom is real but not separable from exposed metadata. Falsifiers: (F1) a calibrated rule beating the solver by ≥+1.0 point (80% CI lower >0); (F2) metadata exposing oracle-gap candidates; (F3) a multi-decoder union exceeding noise.

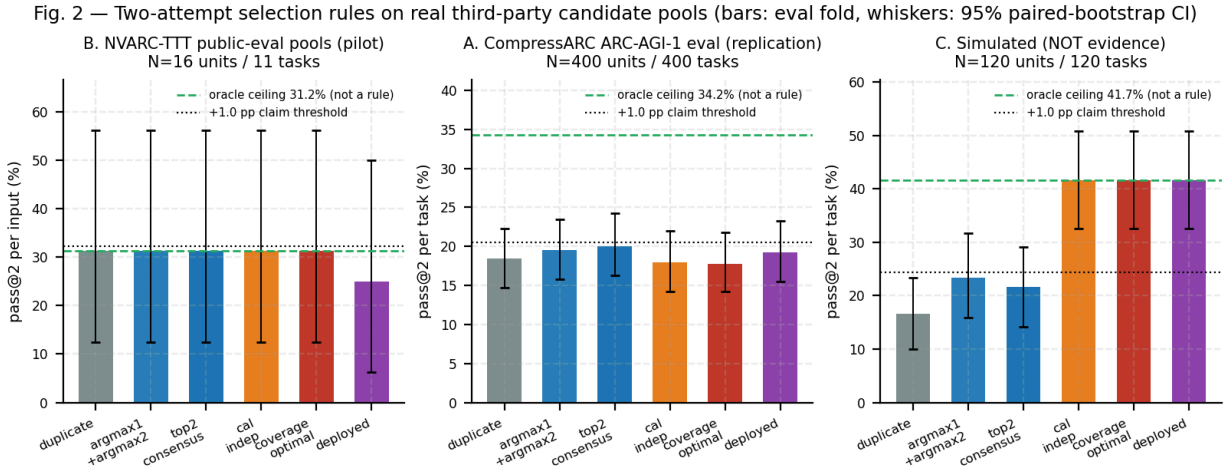


Figure 2. Rule comparison with bootstrapped CIs: pass@2 and paired Δ vs the published baseline, per dataset (B pilot; A replication; C simulated). Oracle coverage is a ceiling, not a rule; bars are the pre-registered 80%/95% intervals; the +1.0-point line applies to the claim-bearing dataset only.

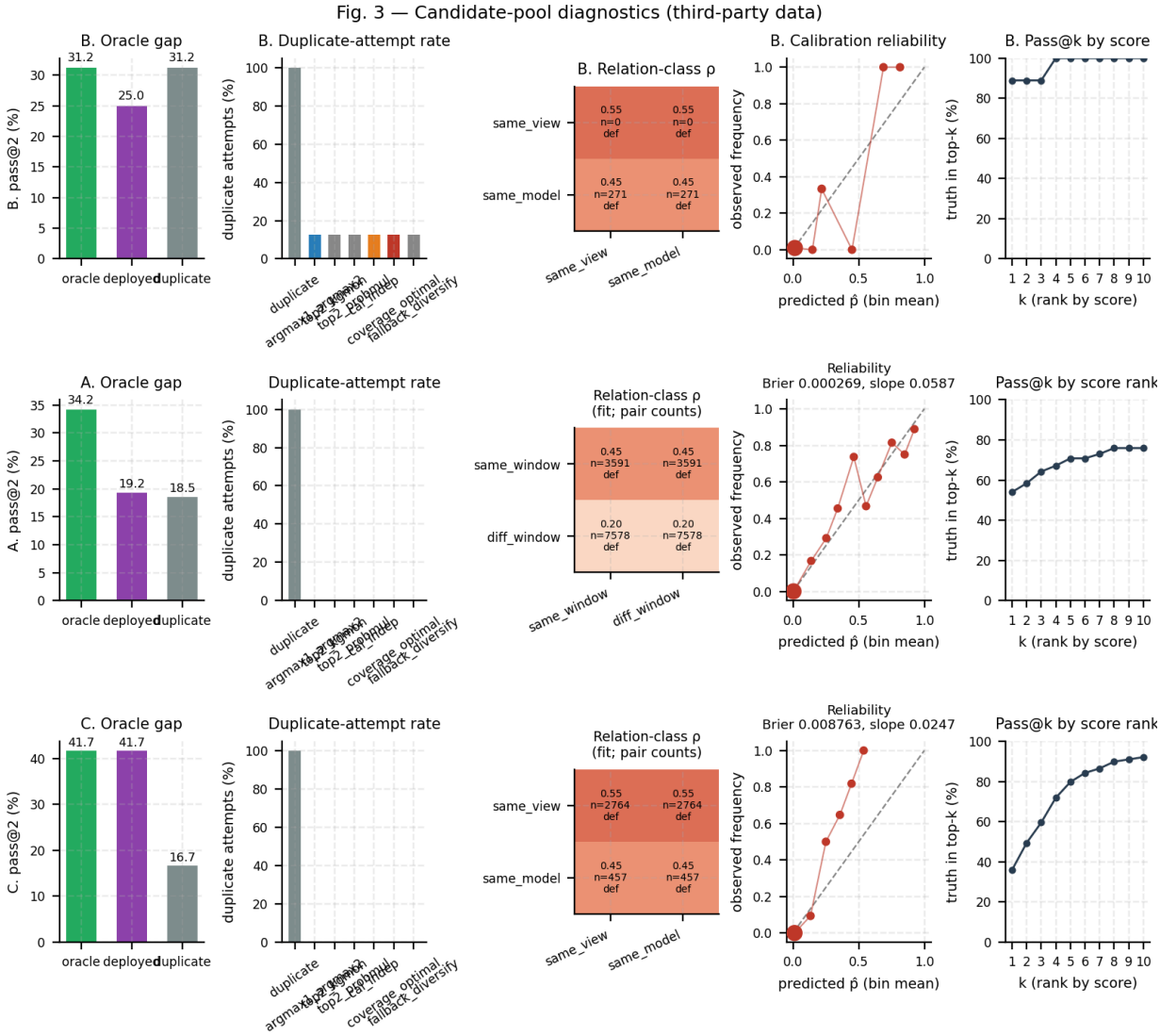


Figure 3. Pool diagnostics: oracle gap, duplicate rates, relation-class ρ heatmap with pair counts, and calibration reliability for B/A and C.

6. Data characterization and leakage audit

We characterize ARC-AGI-2 data [20]: 1,000 training tasks (3,232 pairs, 1,076 inputs) and 120 evaluation tasks (358 pairs, 172 inputs); the repo mirror (167 inputs) is not used for scores. A SHA-256 audit finds zero shared tasks, pairs and input grids between training and evaluation.

Heuristic baselines solve 1.6% training, 1.5% holdout and 0% eval; eval grids are larger (21.95 vs 14.67, p<0.001) and 54.5%/57.5% of train/eval tasks are same-size rewrites.

quantity	value	artifact
train / eval tasks	1,000 / 120	§1
shared tasks / pairs / input grids	0 / 0 / 0	§12
trivial-heuristic solve: train / holdout / eval	1.6% / 1.5% / 0%	§13
max grid dimension: train vs eval	14.67 vs 21.95 (p<0.001)	§11
solvability tiers A/B/C	28 / 56 / 36 (uncalibrated)	§15

Table 6. Data-characterization summary (public ARC-AGI-2; unless noted).

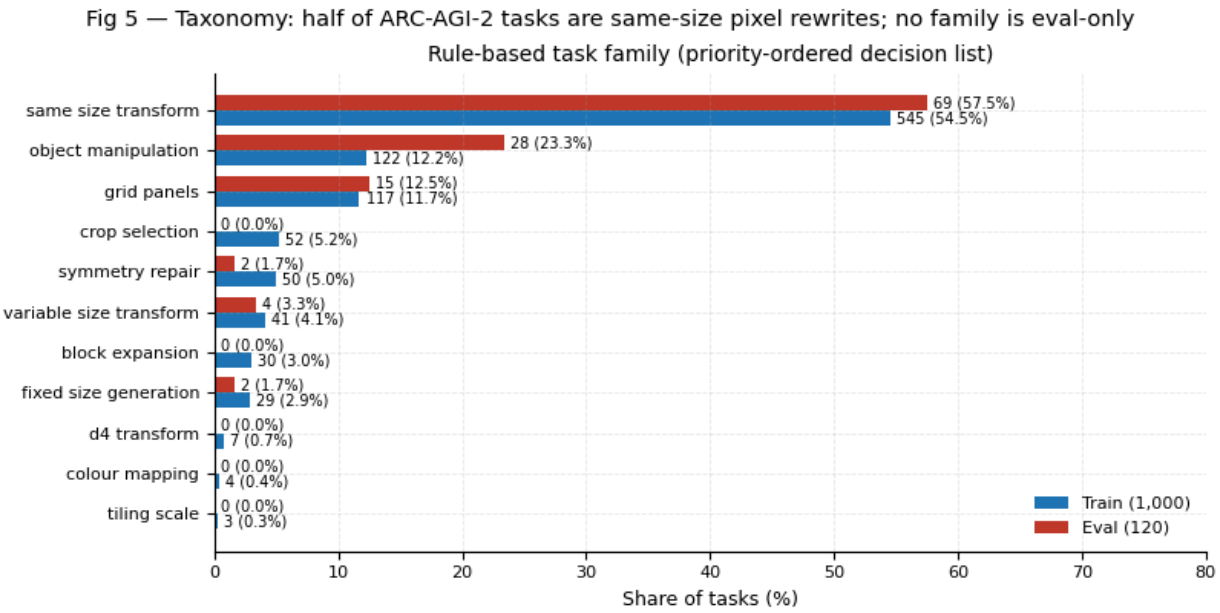


Figure 5a. Rule-based task-family distribution for 1,000 training and 120 public-evaluation tasks (analysis/report.md §9). Same-size rewriting dominates both; no family is evaluation-only.

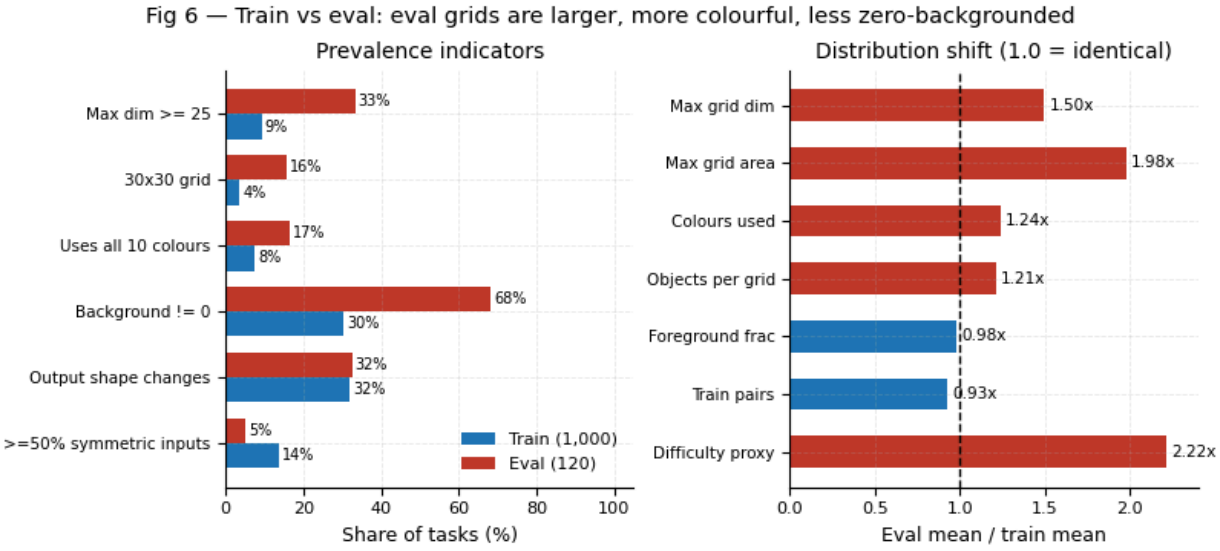


Figure 5b. Train-vs-evaluation shift: prevalence indicators (left) and eval/train mean ratios (right) for size, palette, demonstrations, and background (analysis/report.md §11).

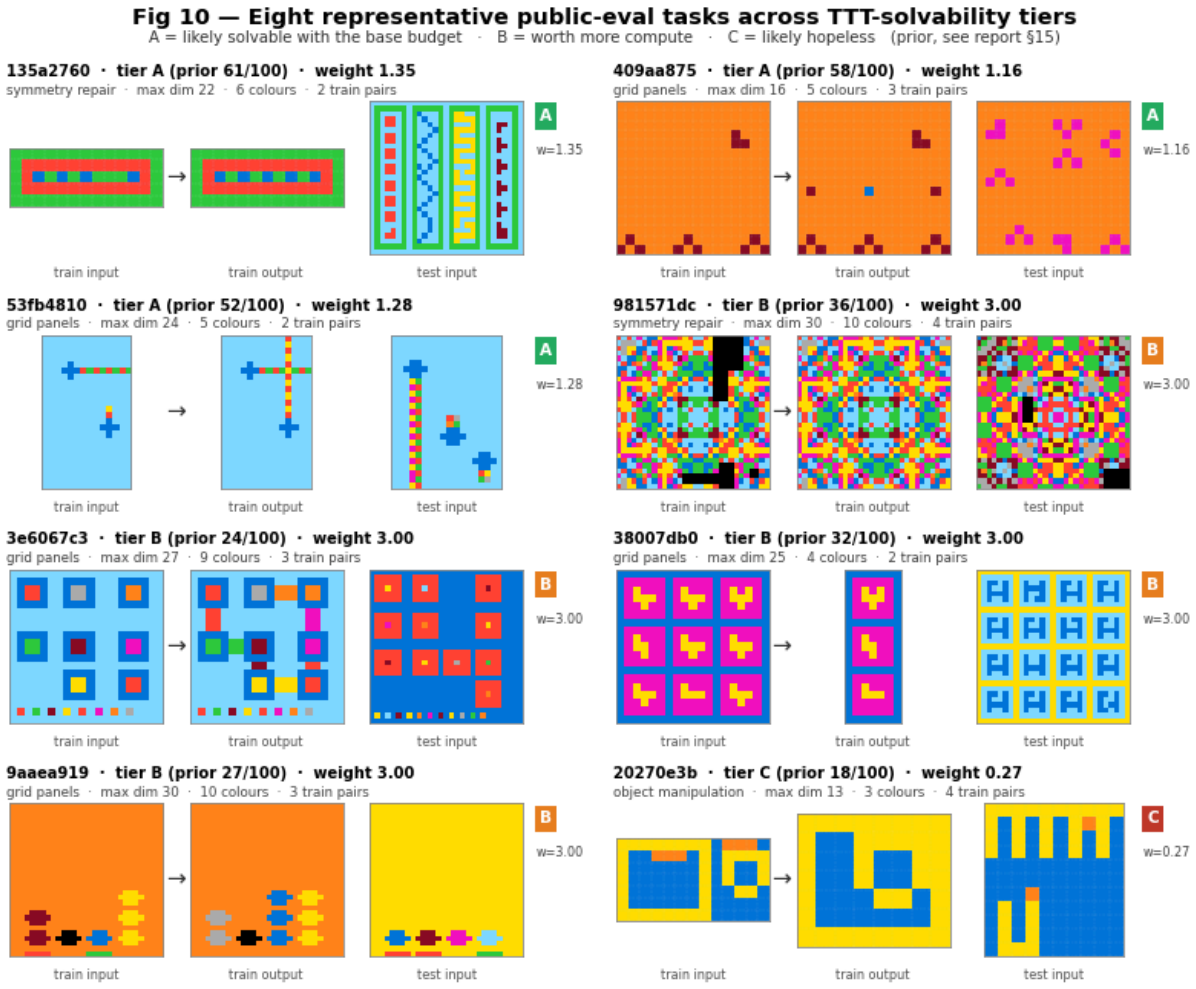


Figure 6a. Eight representative public-evaluation tasks across prior tiers with budget weights (analysis/report.md §15); tiers are an uncalibrated prior, not a solve rate.

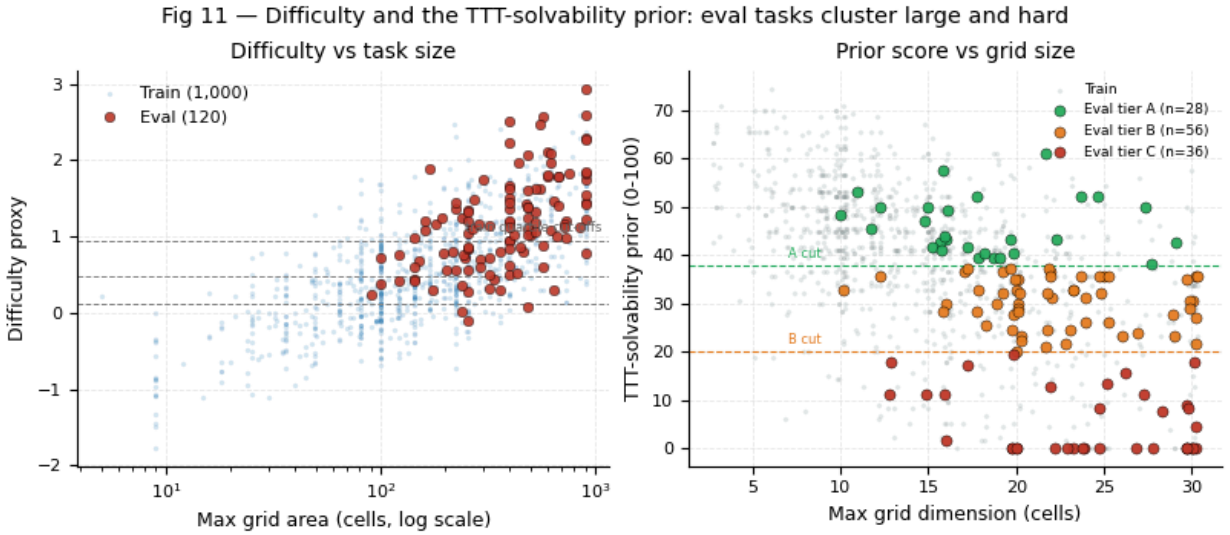


Figure 6b. Difficulty proxy and the uncalibrated TTT-solvability prior versus task size (analysis/report.md §15–16).

7. Completeness: engineering and reproducibility

The repository implements loader, augmentation, threshold-DFS decoding, rescoring, aggregation, coverage rules (§3), TTT and orchestration; it runs offline from a kernel mount. Released under

MIT-0; third-party components retain licences (ARC-AGI-2, Qwen3, CompressARC, arc-dsl, Unsloth/peft). Notebook methods are clean-room re-implemented and cited; a NOTICE records attributions. The `LICENSE` file must switch to SPDX `MIT-0` before release.

GPU fixes: Triton needs an explicit `TRITON_PTXAS_PATH=/usr/local/cuda/bin/ptxas` (missing ptxas → zero candidates), and Hugging Face loading needs offline weights (`local_files_only`/mount). The packet pins source/hash and forces deterministic fallback; Validation: 190 passing CPU tests (~26 s); a schema-valid fallback: the 167-input packet ran in 8.3 s on Kaggle, while the official 172-input repackaging measured 5.4 s locally and scores 0/120 — a safety net, not accuracy; TTT-path validation with a tiny Qwen model (dialect guard, LoRA, 2 steps, 8-view decode, selection, schema); and a CompressARC harness that re-derives bundled predictions and exports hash-level pools for Dataset A.

component	validation evidence	status
CPU test suite	190 tests pass (~26 s)	measured
CPU fallback submission	repo 167-input packet 8.3 s on Kaggle; official 172-input repackaging 5.4 s local, 0/120 (safety net)	measured
TTT path (tiny model)	tokenizer guard, LoRA, decode, selection, schema OK	measured
GPU dev2 pilot	2 tasks, 15 candidates, per-task walls 202.5/238.1 s, load 106.9 s	measured
Engineering fixes	ptxas/HF-offline guards; void stale-packet run root-caused	measured
First submission attempt	57456856 errored (rerun-only budget parse); CPU-probe retry (57500870) publicScore 0.00	measured failure
First scored hidden run	**57663405**, S1 L4, COMPLETE **publicScore 14.17** (≈14 h incl. queue)	measured (scored)
Best scored hidden run	**57681632**, S5 L4, COMPLETE **publicScore 16.25** (current best; +2.08 pp over S1)	measured (scored)
S6 dual-config rerun	Oct 28 submission	PENDING
CompressARC reproduction	137/400 solved; 80/400 pass@2	measured

Table 5. System and reproducibility matrix.

8. Public-solver landscape and what transfers

Table 4 has ten notebooks [16–19]; nine cluster at 29.7–31.4. TRM [5], SOAR [7], deep ensembles [11] are not evaluated.

Saved artifacts are partial reruns (vanductan 5/120; 8/172; others 2–4/120).

notebook (family)	displayed	claimed	mechanism	transferable element
mayankraaz	31.39	35.97	triple-pass pooled TTT, controller, LOO-DSL	cheap-first ordering; pass-A invariant
yuvrajlamba01	31.39	54.31%	TTT + deterministic symbolic solver	monotone symbolic filler
rabari9999	30.97	n/a	v38 perf patch clone	GPU-side log-softmax patch
vanductan	30.97	n/a	perf-patched research dump	candidate-pool logging (Dataset B)
mikelou1 / anthonyxlyu	30.14	33.89	v38 minimal perf patch	algebraically identical speed patch
woominyo	29.72	n/a	perf patch + interleaved ensemble	attempt ordering via interleaving
dmitriigluzdov	29.17	n/a	+6 transformer layers	negative result — capacity expansion
delongyang	15.69	n/a	27B FP8 zero-shot	model-size/throughput trade-off
cprs	30.56	80%+ target	TTT + LLM program-synthesis pre-pass	verified-program candidate source

Table 4. Public-solver landscape (dated reading 2026-10-18; displayed scores are secondary-source context).

9. Limitations, ethics, and reproducibility

The largest limitation is that our solver has **six scored hidden submissions** spanning **14.17–16.25** (champion S5 16.25), versus **20.0% task-level** on the 20-task public-eval subset — S1/S5 gaps ≈5.8/≈3.75 points consistent with half-cost truncation and subset noise, not distributional. Compute quota was exhausted Oct 31–Nov 1, leaving no GPU for further tuning; the ~30 public-notebook band is external context only. The first rerun (57456856) errored after ≈2 h 34 min with no publicScore; probe 57500870 scored 0.00. No per-task hidden observability exists, so variance cannot be reported. The selection claim remains a third-party-pool study with narrow conclusions; B is tiny (29 inputs/20 tasks), A overlaps ARC-AGI-2 training, C validates only estimator/implementation.

D1/D2 caveats. The D1 inputs are empirical consistency proxies, not true posteriors; metadata are partial (third-party dumps; pilot/CompressARC lack shape/view metadata), so `I` is a lower bound and the certificate may overstate achievable coverage; hidden-task transfer is an explicit exchangeability assumption, not a guarantee. Label gaps: `/tmp/dv15/logs` and `logs/pools` were missing, so archived dev20 paths were used; dev20 has only 16/32 units and wide CIs; S6 is selection-bug-affected; S5_ens is a 53-task superset; the +8.11 pp S5_ens headroom is selectable, not realized (hidden 15.42 < S5 16.25). T6 is a **negative result** plus a conditional certificate: certificates are vacuous on all pools ($I \geq 2T^2$); gain=T holds on dev20 S2/S5/S5_ens (ratio 1.00) while CompressARC loses −2.25 pp; Prop. 6f is tight only under score sufficiency. D2 is a definitional candidate-prefix replay, not T7 evidence; T7′s only support is the hidden-score ladder, **consistent not conclusive** (n=6; truncation; S6 bug; 53-task superset; packet/config differences; unknown hidden size). The theory is bounded: coverage identities are exact, but $\hat{p}$ and $\hat{\rho}$ are estimates; the gate is a guard, not a guarantee; the TTT discussion is a sketch.

All data are public (ARC Prize data, notebook outputs, CompressARC artifacts); no personal data, credentials or hidden-test information is used. Third-party artifacts are used with attribution; no third-party code was copied. Reproducibility depends on Appendix B artifacts and on the repository reaching a single consistent licence before release.

10. Conclusion

Coverage is the right formalization for two-attempt selection: independent correctness makes top-2 optimal, correlated errors make a calibrated pair rule provably better, and Theorem 4 gives the correlation threshold. The measured answer is a bounded negative: on real public pools the solver's score ordering

saturates recoverable coverage. On 400 CompressARC tasks top-2 covers 20.00% while the coverage rule covers 17.75%, against 34.25% oracle — 14.25 points exposed metadata cannot reach. The verdict is `DOWNGRADE_TO_ANALYSIS`; selection is not the bottleneck, candidate generation/coverage is. The information view sharpens the result: Theorem 6 bounds any metadata rule by `p1+p2+min{T,sqrt(I/2)}`, so the 34.25% vs 20.00% gap is an identification deficit, not a ranking failure; the certificates are vacuous on every pool ($I \geq 2T^2$), so T6 is proven rather than empirically separated; on dev20 S2/S5/S5_ens selection recovers the tail T exactly (ratio 1.00), while CompressARC loses −2.25 pp, and the S5_ens headroom is selectable but unrealized. Theorem 7 (conditional) makes the separation explicit: verifier-free compute leaves `ΣΔ_t` unchanged while identifiable coverage scales; the hidden-score ladder (16.25 > 15.42 = 15.42 > 14.17) is consistent but confounded, not conclusive. Transferables: the formalization, information bound, protocol, benchmark, data audit, implementation, real attempt and record — plus falsification targets: held-out gain outside the certificate, large $\hat{I}$ with zero gain, a vacuous bound with zero gain, or a monotonicity violation.

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Appendix A — Pre-registration (condensed from `research/design/selection_protocol_v2.md`)

- **Sources frozen before evaluation:** B = `vanductan/arc-agi-2-candidate-dump` (pilot; 29 inputs/20 tasks — no other public candidate-dump notebook was found); A = CompressARC bundled predictions (claim-bearing; 400 ARC-AGI-1 eval tasks, fit on 400 train; hash-level candidates).
- **Reproduction gates:** B must reproduce 29 units, oracle 9, top-2 8; A must reproduce 137 solved and 80 pass@2 at 2,000 steps. A failed gate excludes the source; it does not trigger rule changes.
- **Units and splits:** B unit = test input, tasks split 9/11 dev/holdout by task hash (13/16 inputs); A unit = task, source-defined split (400/400).
- **Frozen scalar scores:** B = Σ of the eight per-augmentation scores (lower better); A = logaddexp-accumulated pick score (higher better).
- **Rules:** duplicate, argmax1_argmax2, top2_consensus, cal_indep, coverage_optimal, oracle_any2, deployed (selected on fit).
- **Features for $\hat{p}$ (fixed order):** score rank percentile, score z-score, log(1+agreement), cluster mass, is-top-cluster, shape consistency (B), cross-model count; A adds log first-step and pick-type diversity.
- **ρ classes:** same_candidate (ρ=1, never paired), same_view, same_source, cross_source (pooled only; no cross-source claim).
- **Statistics:** paired bootstrap over tasks, 2,000 resamples, seed 0; 80% and 95% CIs; claim iff $\Delta \geq +1.0$ point and 80% CI lower > 0 on the claim-bearing holdout.
- **Verdict:** Dataset A does not meet the pre-registered margin — coverage_optimal 17.75% vs argmax1_argmax2 19.50%, margin −1.75 pp (required: ≥+1.0 point with 80% CI lower bound >0) — so the selection claim is `DOWNGRADE_TO_ANALYSIS` and the deployed rule is the no-calibration fallback. Dataset C is simulated and therefore never enters the claim.
- **Deviations:** any change is a new protocol version committed before the affected holdout is read; both versions reported.

Appendix B — Evidence registry and per-number provenance

All numbers map to rows in `paper/evidence_table.md` (Plan C). Primary artifacts: `analysis/results/selection_benchmark.json` (Table 2 and Fig. 2; command `python analysis/selection_benchmark.py`); `logs/arch-theorist/external_reproduction_gate_arc2_dump.json` (Dataset B reproduction gate); `code/out/compressarc/verify_bundled_eval.json` (Dataset A reproduction gate); `analysis/report.md` (data characterization); `analysis/results/saved_artifact_scores.json` (landscape); `logs/kaggle_freeze.md` and `logs/kaggle_runs.md` (platform gate); `code/docs/RESULTS.md` (CPU baselines and system validation). The theorem and the pre-registration are documented in `research/design/theory.md` and `research/design/selection_protocol_v2.md`, released with the paper bundle. GPU end-to-end execution and our own leaderboard score are **not measured** (platform-gated) and are never cited as results.

Appendix C — Platform-gated access log (summary)

Thirteen Kaggle runs recorded between 14:00 and 15:06 UTC on 2026-10-18, all CPU-only: five environment/mount/tokenizer probes, three fallback-packet dry runs, five TTT-packet smoke runs. GPU entitlement was requested (`NvidiaL4`, `NvidiaTeslaT4`) and not granted; competition attach was rejected pending rules acceptance, which requires phone verification. Zero Kaggle GPU-hours were consumed; the frozen handoff bundle contains packet checksums and a resume procedure that regenerates packets before pushing. No hidden-test data was accessed and no GPU number appears in the paper. **V4 update (2026-10-21):** the competition gate cleared; kernel v8 dev2 pilot measured on 4×L4 (§4.3). Submission **57456856** reran (2026-10-21T00:01:15Z) and errored before compute: the rerun branch set `ARC_BUDGET_S="41400.0"` and the run cell's `int("41400.0")` raised `ValueError`; Kaggle's ≈2 h 34 min was queue time. Hardening (int-typed budgets, no-raise validation, sanitization, SAFETY cell, rerun-simulation gate) landed; probe 57500870 scored 0.00; L4 refs 57663405=14.17, 57681632=16.25; S6 15.42.

Appendix D — Reproduction commands

```
# data analysis, split, baselines, allocation, figures (CPU, 169 s)
bash analysis/run_all.sh

# selection benchmark on third-party pools (CPU; needs the downloaded dumps)
python analysis/selection_benchmark.py

# repository tests and CPU baselines
python -m pytest code/tests -q
python code/compressarc_harness.py verify-bundled --out code/out/compressarc/
verify_bundled_eval.json
```

Appendix E — Diversification-threshold derivation, P1/P2 protocol, and falsifier

Theorem 4 and its corollaries are stated in §3.4; the full derivation, edge cases, and the exact inversion of the threshold are in `research/design/theory.md` §4.2. The empirical protocol is frozen in `research/design/selection_protocol_v2.md` §6d and implemented in `research/design/diversification_threshold.py` (self-test covers theorem arithmetic, admission/bootstrap mechanics and pilot flagging). On `pool-v1` logs from our own GPU runs: unit = (task, test input); task-level fit/holdout split by `sha256(task_id)` parity; $\hat{p}$ from the frozen dev-fit logistic calibration and $\hat{\rho}_c$ from the method-of-moments co-failure estimator per relation class (same_view, same_model_cross_view, score_tied, cross_model), clipped to [−0.95,0.99]; δ=0.05; pairs cap at the top 32 by $\hat{p}$. Rules compared on holdout units: top-1 duplicated, threshold-diversify (admit iff $\hat{\rho}_c < \rho^* - \delta$), and the ungated coverage-optimal contrast. Pre-registered predictions: **P1** admitted pairs beat their duplicate counterpart (paired $\Delta>0$, 80% CI>0); **P2** rejected (score-tied) pairs do not ($\Delta\leq 0$); **P3** predicted-vs-realized gain slope in [0.7,1.3]. Falsifier: failure of P1, P2 or P3 falsifies the estimator/relation-class instantiation, never the algebra. The dev20 pools (65 base tasks / 133 task-pools) were analyzed; exact-match exclusivity makes P1/P2/P3 untestable (theory §4.8): every class has $\hat{\rho}<0$, so Table 10 is a prose check and Fig. 9 is omitted.

Appendix F — Official competition data note

The official evaluation files (`data/comp/`, sha256 prefixes `e7c62a4b…` / `84be4f4f…`) contain 120 tasks and **172** test inputs; the repo mirror distributed with the public data has 167. Five tasks differ: four add an extra test input (inserted first, so attempt order shifts), `faa9f03d` also differs in its train pairs, and `d8e07eb2` has a different train-pair output. Repo-mirror scores are therefore not official scores, and all official numbers in this paper are computed by `analysis/official_scoring.py --recompute-all`. The local `arc-agi_test_challenges.json` file (240 tasks / 259 inputs) is an exact content duplicate of 240 public training tasks and is a local dev sandbox only; it is never compared to the hidden leaderboard.

Rerun budget: 4 workers × 12 h for ~240 tasks / 259 inputs gives 12.0 min per task / 11.1 min per input (10.8 / 10.0 min with a 10% margin). Dataset B's selection benchmark attached truth from the repo mirror; the one differing task present in B (`abc82100`) has no candidate matching any repository or official truth for its decoded input, so no rule covers it and the B row is unchanged (checked in `paper/official_b_truth_check.md`).

Appendix G — Theorem 5 derivation, dev20 protocol, and falsifiers

Appendix G / Table 11 (reserved): Theorem-5 derivation (Jensen, KKT/exchange, single-crossing, saturation); dev20 ladder S1/S2/S5/S5_ens ⟶ per-task wall, candidates, coverage, marginal gains by $\hat{p}$ proxies; PENDING/EXPLORATORY.

Appendix H — Exploratory cross-source note

An exploratory check on the partial saved artifacts (task-level 50/70 dev/holdout split, source quality estimated on dev only) found no conversion: on the 70-task holdout the best dev source solves 1/70, best-source attempt-1 plus cross-source attempt-2 also solves 1/70, while the union oracle is 8/70. Cross-source diversification does not convert the observed pool headroom on these partial artifacts. This is an appendix note only; it is not part of the pre-registered study, the artifacts are partial eval-mode runs rather than leaderboard reruns, and source quality was estimated on the dev split only.